MANDAR DEODHAR



ORDER, ORDER New Maharashtra assembly speaker, the BJP's Rahul Narwekar, with CM Eknath Shinde and deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis

caste-and-community game. If its spectacular back-to-back wins in 2014/17/19/22 are seen as a natural outcome of a Hindutva party playing on a home pitch, the truth is that a carefully chosen set of inductees helped it take slices of the social map from other patent-holders, the SP and BSP. Clue? As many as 12 out of 53 Yogi 2.0 ministers are politicians from non-saffron backgrounds. This includes even deputy CM Brajesh Pathak—an erstwhile confidant of BSP supremo Mayawati who joined the BJP in 2016 and has now become a useful Brahmin face, helping blunt the old charge of 'Thakurvaad' that was levelled against Yogi.

Before 2022, the BJP also relied on a string of Pathak's erstwhile BSP colleagues: the likes of Swami Prasad Maurya and Dharam Singh Saini (who together attempted a reverse exodus to the SP, in vain, before elections this year) and S.P. Baghel, all once part of Mayawati's growth story in the state. The BJP persisted with Baghel, despite his early lack of success after crossing over in 2014. They made him national president of the party's OBC *morcha*, and once he won from Tundla this year, he was ensconced in Modi's cabinet as MoS, law and justice. What helps the party make inroads into the communities these leaders represent is also the parallel focus on welfarism, which allows non-BJP figures to rationalise their switch.

Another massive social bloc where a touch of welfarism never goes amiss is India's tribal population, a major focus area for the party. Also an area of concern, because development policies do not always sync well with tribal interests. "Our presence and hold in the tribal areas is declining day by day. We need to establish a strong connection," a top BJP leader told the party leadership at a recent meeting in Delhi. The poaching of senior tribal leader Ashvin Kotwal, the party's latest acquisition from the Congress in Gujarat, will add another string to its bow as the party seeks to build bridges with Adivasis in that state as also in MP, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan. All four are poll-bound states, and the Congress had won 86 of the 128 seats reserved for Scheduled Tribes in these states in 2017-18. That Draupadi Murmu is slated to be the next President will not harm the cause either, but that's an aside to this story.

DEFECTORS HAVE PLAYED A PIVOTAL ROLE IN EXPANDING THE BJP FOOTPRINT ACROSS INDIA, BESIDES ENRICHING THE PARTY'S TALENT POOL AT THE CENTRE. BUT IT IS FINALLY A DOUBLE-EDGED SWORD

The upshot is that the dominant species may have everything it takes to enact its key role: proliferate and thrive in such a manner that it turns the ecosystem itself to its advantage, affecting it in ways that aid its self-preservation. But the surrounding Indian political ecosystem, alien in large measure for a traditionally north Indian *savarna* party is rich and complex enough to effect changes within the dominant species too. Defectors have played a pivotal role in expanding the saffron footprint across India, besides enriching the party's talent pool at the Centre. But it is finally a double-edged sword. Despite the sometimes over-enthusiastic enactments of Hindutva by new converts like Himanta and Bommai, no one has yet alleged that the conversions are happening primarily because of ideology. The latter is merely a vestment the neo-initiates perforce don. And the fact is that most turncoats do come from different political cultures. Often, as with the Congress, those cultures are freer, individualistic spaces that allow a lot more latitude to satraps. Their presence in a collectivised party like the BJP, with its strong roots in the RSS culture, increases the sense of insecurity among existing cadre and threatens to dilute political values. "It might be a good strategy when the party is growing, but the real test will be during the downturn. Will they stick around? Are they not joining because of political opportunism? There are flipsides to the story with uncomfortable questions," says a top BJP leader. For now, though, those questions can be deferred. The conquest of India is afoot. ■

–With ***Bureau Reports***